

Messaging Spend Control

Email & WhatsApp cost visibility, monthly limits and overspend alerts · Status report, 26 September 2026

In one line: we can now see exactly what every email and WhatsApp message costs us, set a monthly spending limit that stops sending before we go over, and get an automatic warning if any day or any hour suddenly costs far more than normal.

1. The problem this solves

Until now we could not answer a simple question: **how much are we spending on messaging this month?** There was no price recorded anywhere, no limit, and no warning. Three real risks came from that:

- **No ceiling.** A large campaign could spend far more than planned, and we would only find out on the invoice.
- **Silent accidents.** Earlier this month a stuck job used up an entire 200,000-message verification allowance in about forty minutes. Nothing was watching, so nobody knew until it had already happened.
- **Running out mid-campaign.** Providers have their own limits (Amazon SES allows 50,000 emails a day). Crossing one does not cost extra — it simply stops sending, leaving half an audience unmailed.

2. What has been built

a) A price list

Every message now has a price. WhatsApp is priced per message by country and by message type (marketing, utility, authentication, service). Email is priced per thousand messages, per provider (Amazon SES, Elastic Email, SendGrid). These rates are entered by us and can be updated whenever a contract changes.

b) A spending limit (the "cap")

We can set a monthly and a daily limit for each channel, in rupees — and for email also in number of messages, because for email the message count usually runs out before the money does.

Important: nothing is ever lost when a limit is reached. A campaign *pauses* with every remaining recipient still waiting in the queue, and continues automatically when the new month starts or the moment we raise the limit. Automated journey messages are simply marked "not sent — spend limit", and the student continues to their next step.

c) An overspend watchman

Every ten minutes the system compares today against a normal day, and the last hour against a normal hour. A day costing **3× more than usual**, or an hour costing **6× more than usual**, sends an alert to Slack and to the alert mailing list. It also warns when a single campaign will use a large share of the monthly budget, and when the month is on course to finish over the limit — early enough to do something about it.

This is the part that catches real accidents, because most expensive mistakes stay *under* the limit. They just spend a whole month's budget in one afternoon, and only a comparison against normal days can see that.

d) Two automatic weekly reports

Every Monday at 7:30 AM, two reports are sent automatically:

- **Consumables bill** — what each channel consumed last week, broken down by message type and provider, compared with the week before.
- **Campaign performance** — every campaign of the week with delivered, opened, clicked and bounced rates, **and its cost**. Cost and performance side by side, so a cheap campaign nobody reads is not mistaken for a good one.

3. Current status

Item	Status
Price list	Live — our rates loaded, editable on screen
Cost recording (all sending)	Live since 26 Sept 2026
Overspend watchman	Live — runs every 10 minutes
Weekly reports	Live — first one goes out Monday 7:30 AM
Spending limits	OFF deliberately — see recommendation below

The limits are switched off on purpose. With them off, nothing can stop a send and our email, WhatsApp and live journeys run exactly as before. The system is currently only *measuring*. We need two to three weeks of measurement to know what a normal month costs, before choosing a sensible limit.

Cost recorded on day one (26 September)

7,515 emails sent	₹ 63.88 email cost	108 WhatsApp sent	₹ 12.42 WhatsApp cost
-----------------------------	------------------------------	-----------------------------	---------------------------------

Channel	Source	Messages	Cost
Email (Amazon SES)	Campaigns	7,255	₹ 61.67
Email (Amazon SES)	Automated journeys	260	₹ 2.21
WhatsApp (utility)	Automated journeys	108	₹ 12.42

Last full week, for scale (14–20 September, 13 email campaigns)

60,154 emails sent	₹ 665.64 estimated cost	~₹ 2,900 projected per month
------------------------------	-----------------------------------	--

Calculated from messages sent × our rate card. Actual cost recording began on 26 September, so weeks before that date are estimates, not ledger entries.

4. Recommendation

When	Action
Now	Turn the email daily message limit on at 45,000 per day with "Stop sending". This protects us from Amazon SES refusing us mid-campaign at its own 50,000 limit. It is well above anything we send in a day, so it changes nothing day to day.
Now	Set the money limits in " Warn but keep sending " mode. We receive the alerts at 50%, 80% and 100%, with zero risk to any campaign.
In 2–3 weeks	With two or three weekly bills in hand, set the monthly limit at roughly double a normal month and switch to " Stop sending ".

5. Where to find it

Admin panel → **Netcore** → **Settings** → **Spend control**. Four tabs:

Tab	What it shows
Caps & live spend	The limits, and what has been spent so far this month
Prices	Our rate card for WhatsApp and email — edit here when a contract changes
Unusual spend	Hour-by-hour cost for the last 48 hours, and any alerts raised
Weekly reports	Last week's bill and last week's campaign performance

A summary line also appears at the top of the Netcore home page, so the month's spend is visible without opening anything.